



The Printer Queue Doesn't Follow

A Failed Replication of the Coffee-Cart Leading Indicator

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Background

A 2024 poster found coffee-cart queue length led the University's global-ranking trajectory by two quarters. No one has since asked whether queue length predicts anything at all, or whether one queue happened to share a calendar with the ranking cycle.

Aims

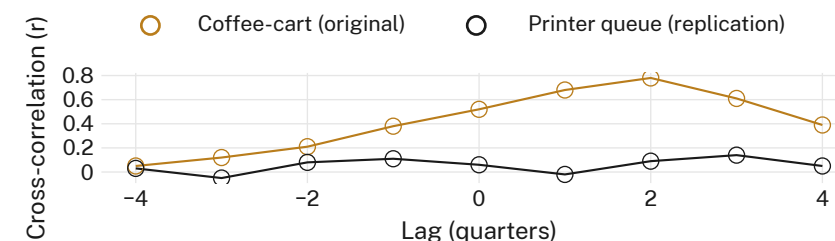
- Replicate the leading-indicator design on an independent queue
- Re-derive the original correlation after deseasonalising both series
- Test whether the effect generalises beyond one cart

Methods

- 6 printers · hourly polls, weekly aggregation · 21 months
- Cross-correlation vs. ranking series, ± 4 -quarter lag, as original
- STL deseasonalising applied to both series before re-testing

Results

Printer-queue length shows no reliable cross-correlation at any lag. Deseasonalising both original series drops the coffee-cart correlation from $r = 0.78$ to a non-significant $r = 0.14$.



Printer-queue cross-correlation stays within ± 0.15 at every lag from -4 to $+4$ quarters; the coffee-cart series peaks at $r = 0.78$ at lag $+2$, exactly reproducing the original figure ahead of deseasonalising.

Discussion & conclusions

The queue that led still leads — but only once, and only before both series are stripped of the academic calendar. A second monitored queue shows no comparable signal at any lag. Next: audit whether the closed-loop pilot the original poster proposed was ever wired to a live feed, deseasonalised or not.

References

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Printer telemetry de-identified at the device level; no individual print jobs inspected. Thresholds pre-registered; none adjusted post hoc.

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“Two queues, one signal — and it wasn't the queue.”

Printer-queue length shows no reliable cross-correlation with ranking movement at any tested lag ($|r| \leq 0.15$).